The Speech and A Breakup Technique DON'T

By Laurie Notaro and Lynn Harris

INTRODUCTION

Breakups are the worst. Sometimes they're the worst because you have lost someone that you truly care about and will miss; sometimes they're the worst because you have put all your eggs in one person-size basket and that person-size basket unceremoniously dumps you; sometimes they're the worst because now what am I supposed to do with my time? Regardless of the reasons surrounding a breakup . . . hearing The Speech is never a good thing. The Speech by Laurie Notaro

The Speech by Laurie Notaro

Relationships suck.

They suck hard.

Sometimes, in the middle of the night, when my bedroom is as black as death, and the sheets on half the bed are as cold as a five-day-old corpse, I think

All ever wanted to be was someone's Old Lady.

I want to be the ball and chain.

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I need to be somebody's squeeze.

I float in this for a minute, in this bed that is too big for me, and feel a little bit lonely when all of a sudden the wheezing, flopping noise from my lungs wakes me up and shocks me back into Relationship Reality, and I realize . . .

The empty side of the bed does not fart in its sleep.

The empty side of the bed does not make me look at the turd as big as my leg grounded in the toilet and then ask aloud, "Dude, do you think it will go down in one flush?"

The empty side of the bed does not wrestle me to the floor, pin me, and then straddle me, in order to do the Spit Torture, dripping saliva out of its mouth over my face, then sucking it back up; dribbling it out, then sucking it back up; dribbling it out, then letting it fall right near my mouth.

The empty side of the bed IS NOT, I repeat, IS NOT a MAN.

And for that, I am thankful.

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I want a man as nice as my retarded dog, but one that doesn't crap on the floor. I want a man who will only cheat on me a little and who will call me once a week. I want a man who will buy his own drinks and who will hold back my hair when I puke. I want a man who is unconfused regarding his sexual identity. I want a man who has never heard of or practiced the Speech.

I will never find him. He has never been born.

The last time I got my walking papers, it was over the phone. "It" had lasted about five months, the longest-standing Relationship Record I had held in this decade. Well, it wasn't even a "relationship." I called it the "thing." He didn't call it anything. He thought I wanted to get married tomorrow, have seventeen kids, and buy an Isuzu Trooper.. All I really wanted was one phone call per solstice.

Anyway, the conversation was off to a running start when he cleared his throat and said,

"I am not ready and will not be ready to actively get involved with anyone for at least three to five years."

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"Why?" I asked. "Are you going to prison?"

"No. What I am saying is that I'm not ready to commit to anything, either way."

"Either way? You mean you can or cannot commit to committing or not committing?" I said, growing suspicious and confused. "Are you giving me 'the Speech'?"

"I think we should concentrate more on the 'Friends' part of our-well, you know."

Suspicions confirmed. I gasped.

"You ARE giving me the Speech! You just gave me the Speech! That was the Speech!" I cried.

So I got the Speech, which automatically drops you to the lowest point in life, it's like throwing the self-esteem balloon on a cactus. You become such a small specimen of existence that you could probably mate with yourself, which would actually be such a terrific advantage.

I guess I took it well. I didn't set anything on fire, practice any voodoo, or listen to sad songs. No, this time I just sat at the bar and drank, sneering and

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growling at all of the men except my friend Dave.

"How's it going?" he asked.

"Well, I got the Speech today," I said.

"Oh no. Not the Speech," he said. "Did he use the 'F' word?"

I nodded.

"Oh God." Dave sighed. "The 'F' word is low. Low down."

"Yep," I said. "Friends. He said, 'We're just Friends.' "

I don't understand the Speech and how men learned about it. Was it a part of boys' eighth-grade PE class, did the gym teacher make them say it to one another over and over in the showers so they would be good at it?

"Okay, now how does it go?"

"It goes, 'You're a cool girl, and I like hanging out with you, but I'm not ready to make a - um, that big word - commitment to one person, and I think we need to be . . . we need to be . . . ' "

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"Man, this is the most important part! The 'F' word, man! The 'F' word!"

"Oh, yeah! You tell the chick you want to be Friends! But you don't mean it, do you?"

"No."

Or maybe the Speech is some kind of computer chip that gets implanted in every baby boy as soon as he's born.

"There are things running around out there with uteruses, son. You're goingto need this."

Could it be a hormonal gift package with an added feature thing, where women get PMS with estrogen, and men get the Speech with testosterone? I don't understand it.

Maybe it's just my destiny to remain alone, eating single-people food like Soup for One, collecting Precious Moments figurines, and thinking that my dog can talk back to me. Oh, God. With any luck, I'll wind up living in a trailer park as a bitter, celibate [woman] with a heart full of hate. I'd much rather be alone and make myself miserable than give someone else the pleasure.

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AWARD HISTORY

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TRANSITION

OK . . . women struggle after a break-up, but so do guys! And they may not have a close friend to confide in . . . so what options do they have? When we had questions about manners in the 1950s, we wrote to Dear Abbey . . . Today when we have questions about relationships, we can write to Breakup Girl! A Breakup Technique DON'T . . . by Lynn Harris

A Breakup Technique DON'T . . .

Dear Breakup Girl,

After three years my girlfriend broke up with me on the phone – and then refused to talk about it because she was late for a movie! When we finally spoke, she

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said, "I'm going out with someone else now, and there is no chance of us getting back together." Her new boyfriend, she said, was a "real man" who could provide for her financially and emotionally in a way I could not (he has a $45,000 job and a $35,000 Jeep, and I am a grad student). I e-mailed her to ask for my stuff back – and her new boyfriend responded, saying he was her soul mate and that she never wanted to see or hear from me again. Then she dropped off a box containing every gift I had ever given her, except the stuffed animals, which, her note said, she'd given to charity.

I don't understand what has happened. I was always kind, caring, and understanding to her, and then she ended the relationship in such a callous manner. How could she continue saying 'I love you' till the end, then two days after breaking up with me jump into a new relationship, claiming this person as a soul mate? All I know is that I am really hurt and . . .

Confused

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Dear Confused,

Does it make you feel at all betrer – in a heaving, hollow sort of way – that your ex has violated just about every breakup rule there is?

1. Phone breakups are not allowed in three-year relationships.
2. While it doesn't work to talk your dumpee ***through*** a breakup, you at least owe it to him/her to talk ***about*** it. Time-management tip: If you're going to be late for the movies, dump him/her afterward.
3. No follow-up calls involving the words "new boyfriend" or "real man" or actual dollar amounts.
4. Gift return is permitted if deemed a necessary purging and healing process, but only with a note saying something like, "I'm sorry, but it will be easier for me to move on without these."

But BG is not in the business of making people

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feel better by saying, "You're right, s/he is very, very bad and wrong!" and leaving it at that. So. What happened? It's possible that she and Mr. Soul Mate were already shagging and she got tired of the complicated scheduling. Or, she wanted a way out – for whatever reason – and happened to see this guy in a Jeep with a big red "Exit" sign over his head.

And sometimes, callous is easier than careful. You behave badly, you don't have to make the time or effort to deal. You rationalize twistedly: "Well, maybe if I'm a huge troll, s/he'll be glad to see/let me go."

All of which hardly makes you feel better right now, but in the long run, it will. So will this: If he really makes $45,000 and spent $35,000 on a Jeep, he has only $10,000 – well, $6,600 after taxes – left for everything else, like food, clothing, and . . . rent. She says he "provides for her"; I say they live in his care.

Love,
Breakup Girl

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